

Keep in mind that no two documentations will ever be the same if they don't follow any standardised practice. This can lead to some mess, making it hard to fetch the right information.

How exactly do we classify something as messy? When most of the documentation pieces don't follow standard practices, it leads to inconsistency and hence a big mess! So how do you declutter messy open source documents?

Decluttering messy open source documentation

It is important to follow a 'documentation style guide'. A style guide is a collection of guidelines for creating and presenting content. Whether you're a standalone writer or part of a large documents team, it helps to keep a consistent style, voice and tone throughout your documentation.

There are several popular style guides available, such as the Red Hat style guide, Google documentation style guide, and Apple style guide. To choose one, first start by defining your requirements. If your requirements do not differ much from other open source projects, you can follow a readily-available style guide, or adapt the same style guide for your own purpose with a few changes here and there. Most of the grammar-related guidelines and content rules may be the same, but overall terminology can vary.

You will also be required to automate the adoption of these style guides within your projects. For this, you can use Vale, which is integrated into the local machinery with a continuous integration (CI) service that will help you to ensure your documentation follows the style guide in a strict manner.

By using the style guide, the overall premise of the documentation will be conveyed to the users in a

Types of documentation

README: This contains basic installation and usage instructions, which is also one of the most essential parts of any open source documentation. It is the first point of information and contact between the potential user or developer and the project.

Reference guides: These might include some basic references to get started with or some docs to contribute to the project.

User facing documentation: This is the most essential part that documents the usability of the project. Without any user-facing documentation most people will be lost as to how to go about working with the project.

Developers' documentation: This aims to support development teams as they continuously make new progress in the project. It should also provide a good pathway to internal development efforts and make sure that the features are communicated well to the stakeholders.

Community content: This includes essential blogs, videos and external content that aim to support community members who would like to refer to the same for a better understanding of the project.

single tone. But since these documents are prepared by a team of technical writers, there can be conflicting writing styles, as these vary from person to person. So how do you standardise the documentation?

Standardising documentation

There are many approaches that can be taken when it comes to standardising documentation. The first one is obviously to create predefined templates which can be used for a variety of roles. These can be used for documenting new features, identifying bugs and issues, and updating the change log to accommodate new stuff that is being added.

Try to develop a standard workflow for publishing your documentation if you are following a Git based workflow. The most standard workflow will be to fork the repo where the documentation is published, add your changes on a local branch, push these changes, make your request and ask for reviews on the same. A positive that comes out of standardising your documents is a better feedback and review process.

Feedback and automated reviews

Standardisation allows you to get users'

feedback and generate automated reviews, which can be taken into consideration for improving the project and the documentation. With this feedback, you can also evaluate whether the information being shared is making sense to users or not. Having a proper feedback service in place through documentation platforms like GitBook helps to verify if the documentation is useful or not.

Always try to seek out subject matter expert (SME) feedback on the documentation. These SMEs can be stakeholders, developers, engineers, or even external contributors. You can also use automated tests and CI to verify if your documentation is following a style guide or not.

Crowdsourced documentation efforts

If you are looking to open source your documentation, perhaps the best way to get started is to provide a quick start guide. The guide can be as simple as 'CONTRIBUTING.md'; basically, a file showing how a person can set up the project and contribute to or use it.

Always try to develop user-centric documentation that signifies the purpose of each project and build learning courses to help new contributors.